



ScribeTribe
WHERE STORIES GROW CLAWS

THE AUTHOR'S FIELD GUIDE

User Guide

Write, remember, illuminate,
bind—and keep every story under
your control.

4.0 BETA · SINGLE-OWNER SELF-HOSTED EDITION



BEFORE THE FIRST PAGE

Know the shape of the Scriptorium

ScribeTribe is a self-hosted, single-owner writing environment. You can write manually, invite AI assistance deliberately, preserve story history, manage continuity, add art, and prepare a reading copy without handing control of the manuscript to the software.

4.0 CLEAN BREAK

Start with a **new, empty** `DATA_DIR`. Never point 4.0 at a 3.x database. Keep ScribeTribe 3.2.2 and its data intact for historical work; there is no in-place migration.



What calls an AI provider?

STAYS LOCAL Manual writing, reading, organizing, copyediting, image upload, backup, import, and publication export do not require a provider call.	LEAVES THE INSTALLATION Page generation, prepared successors, continuity extraction, AI painting, narration, and other explicit AI actions send necessary context to your configured provider.
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Contents

01	Install & unlock	3	06	History & recovery	9
02	Library & navigation	4	07	Chronicle & Codex	10
03	Begin a manuscript	5	08	Gallery & Gate	11–12
04	Templates	6	09	Safety & operations	13–15
05	The Desk	7–8	10	Quick reference	16



01 · FIRST RUN

Open a sealed local Scriptorium

ScribeTribe runs on your own machine and binds to `127.0.0.1` by default. Node.js 22.5 or newer is required.

Quick installation

```
git clone https://github.com/rthorman/scribe-tribe.git
cd scribe-tribe
bash setup.sh
$EDITOR backend/.env
./start.sh
```

Open `http://localhost:3000`. On the first launch, the terminal prints a one-time setup code. Enter it in the browser, then choose a distinctive password or passphrase of **15–128 characters**.

Before starting 4.0

- 1 Create a new empty data directory. If the checkout already has 3.x data, set `DATA_DIR=../database-v4` in `backend/.env`.
- 2 Optionally set a provider key. Manual work does not need one.
- 3 Start the server and keep the terminal available for status and recovery.

First unlock

- 1 Copy the one-time code from the server terminal.
- 2 Set the owner password. There are no usernames or multiple roles.
- 3 Enable **Keep this scriptorium unlocked** only on a device you control.

SAFE DEFAULT

Keep `HOST=127.0.0.1`. For durable access from another device, use an HTTPS reverse proxy to the loopback server. Direct LAN HTTP exposes passwords and manuscripts in transit.

Daily lock and recovery

- **Lock** revokes the current browser session.
- **Settings** → **Security** changes the password and revokes other sessions.
- If the password is forgotten, stop the server and run `npm run auth:reset -- --yes` from `backend`. This removes the local owner and sessions, not manuscripts or media.

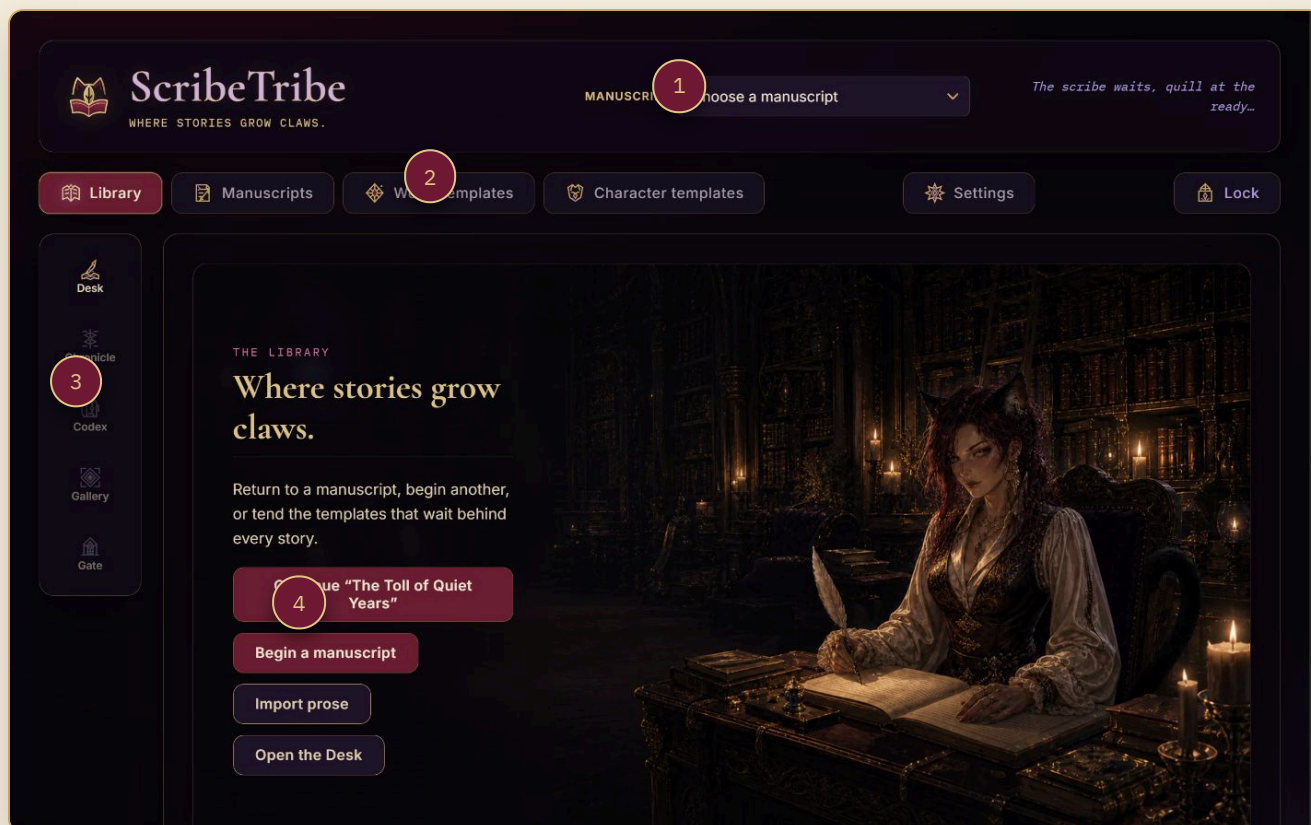
ACCESS CONTROL, NOT DISK ENCRYPTION

The web password does not encrypt the SQLite database, images, audio, or portable archives. Use full-device encryption and protect exported files.

02 · ORIENTATION

The Library is the threshold

The Library owns manuscripts, reusable templates, import and restore, recent work, recovery notices, and the path to Settings. Select a manuscript to enter its five-destination workspace.



Desktop Library. The gothic frame orients you; actions remain literal and the manuscript surface stays quiet.

- 1 **Manuscript selector** — switch the active story.
- 2 **Global destinations** — Library, manuscripts, templates, Settings, Lock.
- 3 **Story workspace** — Desk, Chronicle, Codex, Gallery, Gate.
- 4 **Start actions** — continue, begin, import, or open the Desk.

Navigation stays named

Desktop and landscape tablet use a labelled navigation rail. Portrait tablet and compact layouts use the same five labels in a bottom bar. Nothing important depends on hover or a hidden gesture.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Global templates can be reused. **Story-local** snapshots belong to one manuscript. The Codex explains the latter; Library templates never silently rewrite an existing story.

03 · ONE SHEET, THREE PATHS

Begin with prose, a seed, or an import

Choose **Begin a manuscript** or **Import prose** from the Library. The start sheet asks only for information needed by the path you choose.

Write the opening

Enter or paste the first page. A title is optional. This is the fastest fully manual path and does not require provider setup.

Give the Scribe a seed

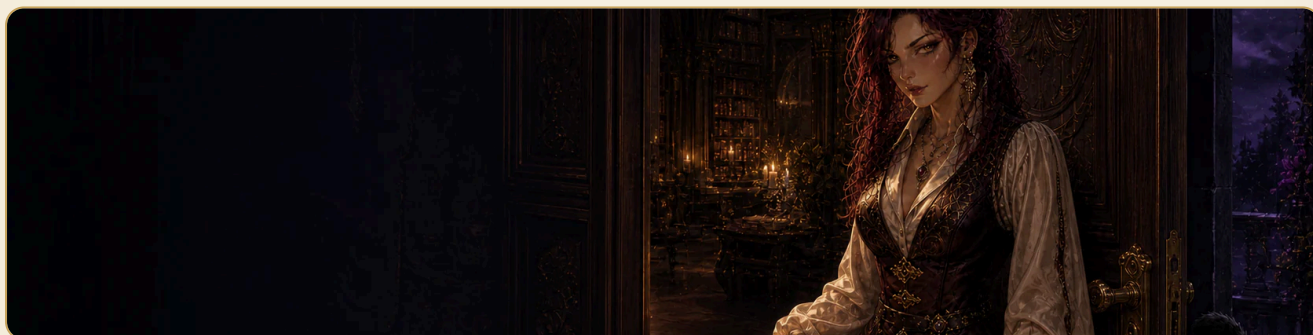
Provide a premise and optional direction. Review provider and cost information before generation.

Import existing prose

Map recognized headings to structure, or begin as a single chapter. Review the result before continuing.

The short start flow

- 1 Choose one start path and name the manuscript.
- 2 Select maturity, narrative role, world, and cast only where relevant.
- 3 Optionally open **Foundations** for premise, voice, point of view, tense, arcs, and constraints.
- 4 Enter the Desk with Volume I and Chapter I already created.



Foundations are guidance, not a gate

AI suggestions in Foundations are drafts. Accept them field by field. You can begin writing without completing every setting, and you can return later.

MANUAL FIRST

Writing, importing, organizing, copyediting, uploading art, and exporting remain available without a provider.

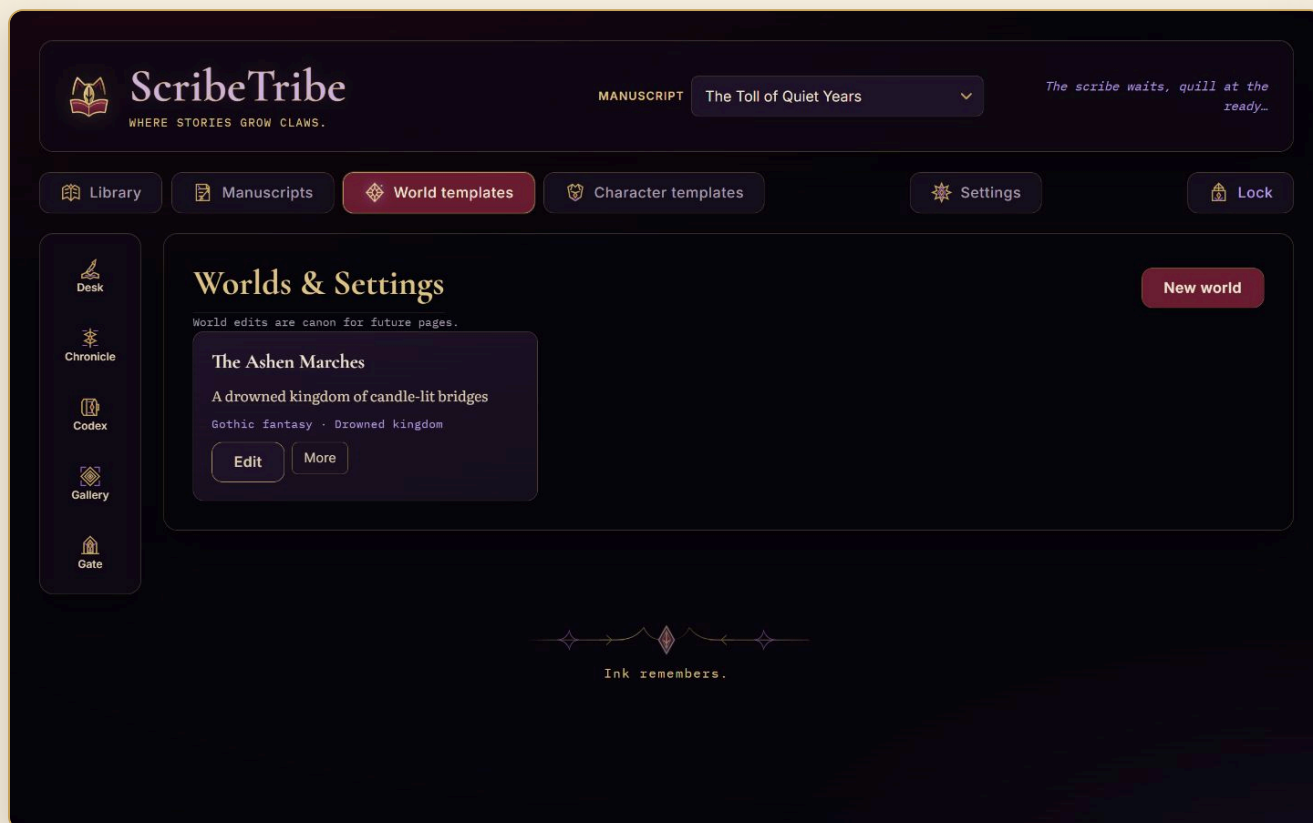
COST-BEARING ACTION

Provider setup appears when you first invoke AI. Read the provider, model, data, and cost review before accepting.

04 · REUSABLE MATERIAL

Build worlds and characters once

World and character templates live in the global Library. They are reusable source material—not remote truth imposed on every manuscript.



The global world catalogue. Create without an image when you want a fully local path; painting is a separate paid action.

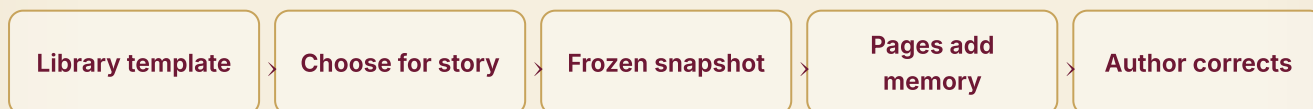
World templates

- Setting, genre, atmosphere, and a lorebook of canonical facts.
- Optional establishing art.
- Reusable across manuscripts.

Character templates

- Identity, appearance, personality, background, and home world.
- Optional reference portrait.
- Reusable in centered or ensemble casts.

What happens when you cast a story?



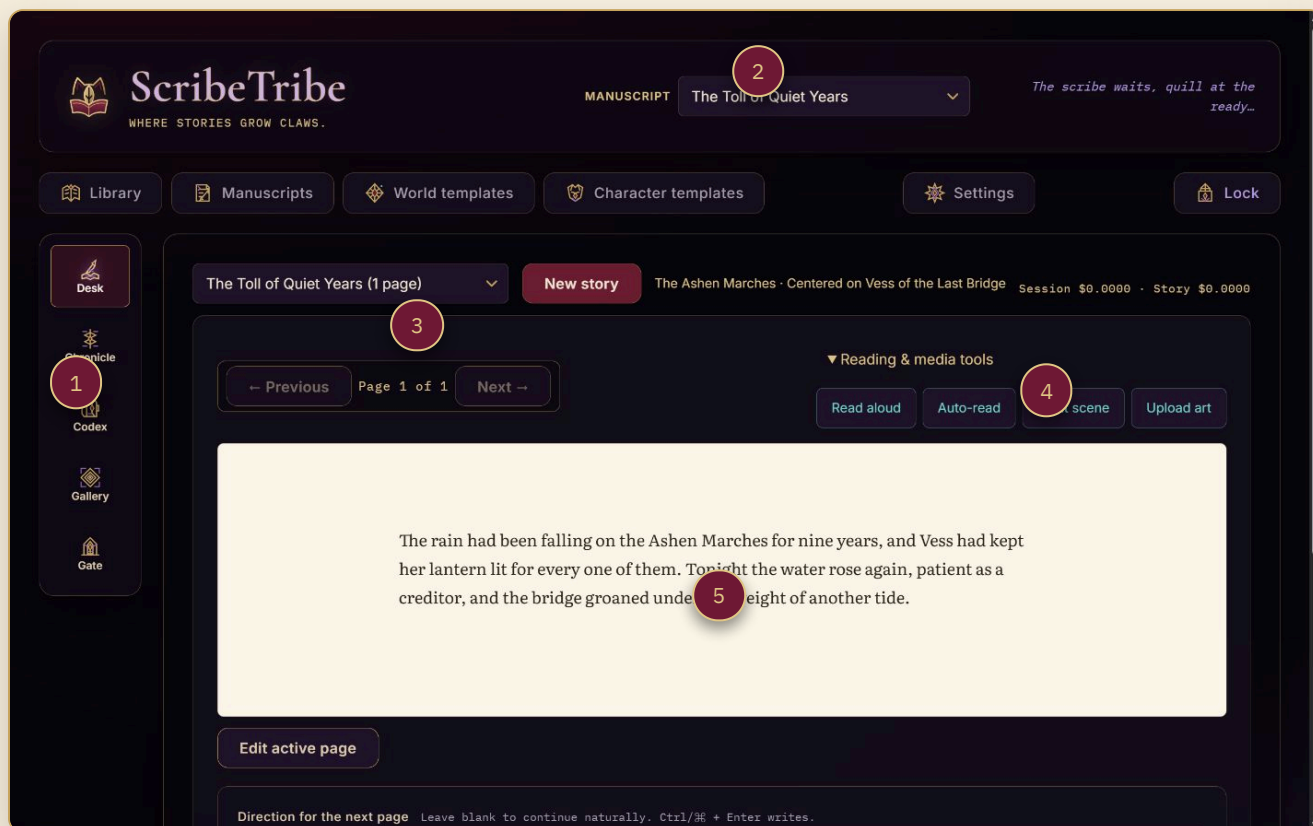
A manuscript receives a story-local snapshot. Later Library edits do not silently change that snapshot. When a template has changed, Codex can show a field-level difference and lets you accept only the fields you want.

CANON RULE

Reusable sheets are reference material. Committed pages, remembered canon, and explicit author corrections define the running story.

05 · THE WRITING LOOP

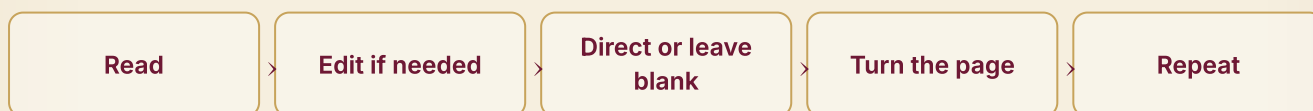
The manuscript stays at the center



The Desk on desktop. Controls frame the prose; artwork never sits behind the manuscript.

- 1 Five stable story destinations.
- 2 Active manuscript and measured session/story cost.
- 3 Previous/next page controls.
- 4 Read-aloud and media tools.
- 5 Editable, quiet manuscript surface.

The ordinary loop

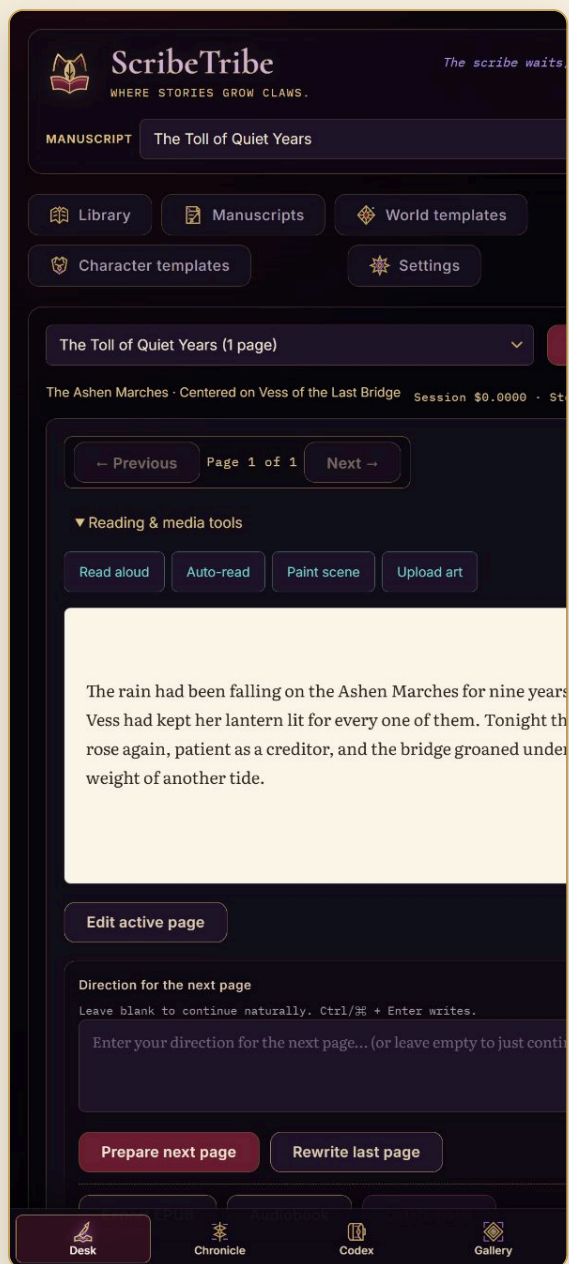


PREPARED SUCCESSOR

After a successful page, ScribeTribe can quietly prepare exactly one successor. Prepared prose is inert: it does not enter canon or continuity until you commit it.

05 · THE WRITING LOOP

The direction changes the action



Portrait tablet keeps the direction composer reachable and the bottom navigation stable.

When direction is empty

If a prepared page waits, **Next Page** commits that exact prose. It does not call the provider for a different version.

When direction has text

The action becomes **Generate as directed**. Pressing it deliberately replaces the waiting preview with a new paid request.

If you clear the direction

The original prepared page is still waiting. The action returns to **Next Page**.

If a request fails

No page is added. Your direction stays visible, and **Try again** names the recovery path.

COST REALITY

A normal AI-assisted page may involve prose, continuity extraction, and preparation of the next page. Estimates are not invoices. Set a hard spending limit on a dedicated provider key.

Other Desk actions

- **Edit active page** changes current prose.
- **Rewrite last page** requests a new version.
- **Read aloud / Auto-read** invokes the selected narrator.
- **Paint scene / Upload art** opens the image path.

Copyedit prose—or return canon

An older page offers two deliberately different operations. Choose by consequence, not by mood.

Action	What changes	What does not	Use when
Copyedit this page	Visible and exported wording.	Remembered Codex state is not recalculated.	Fix spelling, phrasing, and presentation without branching canon.
Return story to this page	Removes all later canonical pages and prepared work.	The removed suffix is retained for bounded recovery.	You want the story to continue from an earlier point.

READ THE EXACT RANGE

The return confirmation names the volumes, chapters, pages, narrative count, prepared work, and recovery period. The action reads **Return and remove N later pages**.



Chronicle keeps the trail visible

Navigate structure

- Volumes contain chapters; chapters contain pages.
- The current tail, prepared page, memory coverage, art placements, and recovery records have distinct markers.
- Rename historical structure without pretending prose can be freely reordered.

Recover safely

- Recovery records show removal time, range, and expiry.
- One-click restore is offered only when the current canon still permits it.
- If later canon diverged, export the removed material rather than silently merging it.



07 · STRUCTURE AND TRUTH

Chronicle says where; Codex says what

Chronicle

Use it to move through volumes, chapters, pages, historical states, and recovery records.

Question: Where am I in the work?

Codex

Use it to inspect story-local foundations, page-provenanced remembered canon, arcs, threads, and corrections.

Question: What is true now?

The three Codex layers

- 1 **Foundations** — author intent and the manuscript's local world/cast snapshots.
- 2 **Remembered canon** — facts, events, conditions, goals, threads, and arc movement linked to source pages.
- 3 **Author corrections** — explicit authoritative overrides with visible impact state.

Correct a remembered fact

- 1 Select a fact or field and inspect its current value and page evidence.
- 2 Enter the corrected value.
- 3 Review detected later conflicts.
- 4 Choose to apply the correction, mark the prose intentional, return the story, or cancel.
- 5 Keep the resulting correction record inspectable.

AI DOES NOT GET THE LAST WORD

AI may summarize possible impacts, but it never applies a correction. Existing prose is never automatically rewritten.

Coverage and repair

If a page lacks a continuity record, the Codex identifies it. Building or rebuilding memory is explicit, proceeds page by page, and receives a cost review. It never triggers a surprise whole-story replay.

Upload or paint, then place deliberately

Two equal paths

Upload an image

1. Choose a file with the native picker.
2. Review the local preview and metadata-removal notice.
3. Add a title and useful alt text.
4. Keep it in Gallery or place it before/after a narrative page.

Paint with AI

1. Write or condense a visible prompt.
2. Choose references and quality deliberately.
3. Review cost and generate.
4. Place the result exactly like uploaded art.

Placement is noncanonical

Moving or unplacing art does not change page numbers, prose, or continuity. Art anchored to a page that is later removed remains stored in Gallery but becomes unplaced.

UPLOAD PRIVACY

An upload is validated, normalized to metadata-free WebP, and kept local. It is not sent to a provider unless you later select it explicitly as a generation reference and grant permission.

PROVIDER REFUSAL

If an image provider refuses a prompt, ScribeTribe explains the refusal, keeps the original upload and prompt unchanged, and shows any sanitized editable prompt. Nothing retries until you press again.

Technical errors stay technical

Unsupported encoding, damaged files, excessive file size, or excessive dimensions are reported as constraints. The application does not semantically classify or moralize about uploaded subject matter.

Backup, publication, and sharing are different

Back up the project

Create a full-fidelity `.scribetribe` v2 archive. Choose whether to include visuals, audio, and working history.

Prepare for publication

Review one normalized book structure, metadata, front/back matter, art, and style before choosing formats.

Share a reading copy

Create an immutable, expiring, revocable snapshot. Anyone holding its capability link can read it.

You need...	Choose...	Remember...
Restorable project state	Full project backup	Portable archives are unencrypted and exclude local credentials, sessions, secrets, and share capabilities.
A book for readers/editors	Publication export	Multiple selected formats come from one normalized snapshot, keeping metadata and structure aligned.
Temporary browser reading	Public reading share	The copy is frozen. Create a new snapshot after material manuscript changes.

Share safely

- 1 Review the included revision, art, and expiry.
- 2 Create the share only behind a correctly configured HTTPS reverse proxy.
- 3 Copy the returned link once and send it through an appropriate private channel.
- 4 Revoke it in Gate as soon as it is no longer needed.

CAPABILITY LINK

Anyone with the link can read the frozen snapshot until expiry or revocation. Never place the capability in query strings, analytics, referrers, proxy logs, or public screenshots.



09 • PRESERVE THE WHOLE INSTALLATION

Use two forms of backup

Portable project backup

Create it in Gate, include the material you need, download it, and store it on encrypted storage.

Portable: good for reviewed transfer and restore.

Cold `DATA_DIR` copy

Stop ScribeTribe and copy the entire data directory as one unit.

Complete: also preserves owner, sessions, recovery state, and local share records.

Before an upgrade

- 1 Record the installed commit, Node version, and data paths.
- 2 Finish active provider/publication jobs and create a full Gate backup.
- 3 Stop ScribeTribe and make a dated cold copy of the complete data directory.
- 4 Install the reviewed release and validate the catalogue before resuming work.

Restore a 4.0 backup

- 1 Start 4.0 with a new, empty `DATA_DIR`.
- 2 Open Gate and preflight the archive.
- 3 Review exposure and collisions; choose **Replace everything** only for an intentional full restore.
- 4 Verify hierarchy, revisions, continuity, media, prepared work, snapshots, and settings.
- 5 Export again and compare with the source evidence.

NEVER MIX GENERATIONS

ScribeTribe 4.0 does not open 3.x databases or import format-v1 archives. Never combine a database from one backup with media or transfer directories from another.

What the portable archive deliberately omits

Passwords, sessions, provider secrets, remembered paid consent, recovery credentials, and public-share capabilities/records. The archive itself is not encrypted.



09 · KNOW THE BOUNDARY

AI is optional; provider consequences are not

ScribeTribe has no maintainer cloud, analytics, advertising, tracking pixels, or crash telemetry. The operator controls the installation and chooses any provider connection.

Credential choices

- **Environment:** a key in the operator-managed backend environment.
- **Session memory:** available only for the current process session.
- **Encrypted vault:** saved locally and unlocked after restart. APIs never return the secret.

SPEND LIMIT FIRST

Create a dedicated provider key and set a hard upstream spending limit before using AI. ScribeTribe's live estimates and session/story totals are good-faith guidance, not an invoice or guarantee.

Typical provider data

- Directions and recent prose.
- Relevant remembered canon.
- Selected world, cast, tone, and model settings.
- Text sent for narration.
- Image prompts and explicitly selected references.
- Prepared successor context.
- Continuity-extraction context.
- Quality and generation settings.

What merely opening the app does not do

Browsing the Library, reading pages, manual editing, organizing, local image upload, publication export, and portable backup do not require an AI call.

LOCAL FILES REMAIN READABLE

The login protects web access, not storage at rest. Anyone who can read the operating-system account or unencrypted disk can read the database and media. Use device encryption and access-controlled backups.

When something is exposed

- Provider key: revoke it at the provider immediately.
- Share capability: revoke the share in Gate.
- Archive: treat it as manuscript disclosure.
- Logs: never publish real prose, prompts, cookies, authorization headers, local paths, or provider responses.

Make the Desk fit the way you work

Input and reading

- Every primary path works with keyboard, touch, mouse, or stylus.
- Visible focus and labelled controls support keyboard navigation.
- Portrait tablet keeps the bottom navigation stable; desktop uses a rail.
- Typography, line length, manuscript theme, and reduced motion persist in Settings.
- Placed publication art should have useful alt text.

Routine states

- **Saved / Saving** appears quietly near the page.
- **Offline—kept locally** means browser-local editing state needs the server again.
- A low-storage banner appears below 1 GB or 5% free space.
- Provider and publication work should settle before shutdown or backup.

Fast diagnosis

Symptom	What to check
4.0 refuses to start	Confirm Node 22.5+ and a new empty <code>DATA_DIR</code> ; do not reuse a 3.x database.
Unlock fails repeatedly	Wait for the temporary throttle, verify the password, or use terminal recovery after stopping the server.
AI action is unavailable	Open Settings; confirm provider profile, credential source, vault unlock, model role, and network access.
Next Page is disabled	A successor may still be preparing. Do not start a competing request.
Continuity looks wrong	Open Codex, inspect page evidence, and apply an explicit correction or rebuild missing coverage.
A removed suffix cannot restore	Later canon diverged. Export the recovery record rather than forcing a merge.
A share does not open	Check HTTPS proxy configuration, expiry, and revocation. Never move the capability into a query string.

BEFORE ASKING FOR HELP

Record the application version, browser, Node version, exact visible error, and correlation reference. Redact manuscripts, credentials, cookies, share links, prompts, and local paths.

10 · LEAVE THIS PAGE NEAR THE DESK

A safe author's checklist

Before writing

- ☐ 4.0 uses a new empty data directory.
- ☐ The provider key has a hard spend limit.
- ☐ The correct manuscript is selected.
- ☐ World and cast snapshots are the intended ones.

During writing

- ☐ Empty direction commits the waiting page.
- ☐ Typed direction deliberately requests a replacement.
- ☐ Copyedit changes prose, not remembered canon.
- ☐ Return story removes later canon with bounded recovery.

Before sharing

- ☐ The snapshot revision and included art are correct.
- ☐ HTTPS is configured and logs omit capability headers.
- ☐ The recipient and expiry are appropriate.
- ☐ The link will be revoked when no longer needed.

Before an upgrade

- ☐ Full Gate backup downloaded.
- ☐ Cold copy of the stopped `DATA_DIR` made.
- ☐ Commit, Node version, and paths recorded.
- ☐ Catalogue and exports validated afterward.

Canonical references

- [README — install and feature overview](#)
- [Security boundary and safe networking](#)
- [Self-hosted privacy notice](#)
- [Operations, backup, restore, and sharing](#)
- [Current beta limits](#)
- [4.0.0-beta.1 release notes](#)

VERSION

This guide describes **ScribeTribe 4.0.0-beta.1**. Interface details can change during the beta; consult the documentation shipped with the installed tag.



The next page is yours.

Keep the manuscript readable, the consequences literal, the provider bounded, and the backups close.